BBC LEARNING ENGLISH

6 Minute English

Is aircon the answer to a heating world?

This is not a word-for-word transcript.

Georgie
Hi Neil.

Neil
Hi Georgie.

Georgie
So, Neil, we've just had a really hot summer in the UK. Did you have air conditioning in your house?

Neil
I didn't have air conditioning in my house. I wish I had, because it was really hot and I couldn't sleep.

Georgie
No, I had one of those big fans, which didn't always do its job. But there is a really serious side to this. Heat records continue to be broken around the world. You may be feeling that summers are getting too hot. Have you been using air conditioning more to cope? If so, you're not alone. Experts are predicting that ten new air conditioning units will be installed every second for the next 30 years. Today on 6 Minute English, we're talking about this and whether air conditioning really is the best way to cope with a warming world. OK. As always, Neil, we'll start with a quiz question. So, modern air conditioning was invented in 1902, but what was it originally used for? Is it:

a) to protect people in hospitals,
b) to dry ink, or
c) to clean air?

Neil
Well, I have absolutely no idea, Georgie. I'm going to guess and say c) clean air.

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Georgie
OK, Neil, we'll find out the answer at the end of the programme.

Neil
OK. Georgie, we've been talking about how uncomfortable the hot weather can make you feel in the summer. Is air conditioning all about comfort, though?

Georgie
No, it's not just about comfort. Summer heat can be a real health issue as well. It's thought that across Europe, over 30,000 people died as a result of this summer's heat. Dr Radhika Khosla, an expert in climatology, told BBC World Service's The Climate Question how important air conditioning can be:

Dr Radhika Khosla
Actually, air conditioning is **life-saving**. You know, in Singapore, when Lee Kuan Yew was asked what made civilisation possible in the tropics, he said it was air conditioning. And there are so many large parts of the world where we would not be able to **inhabit** if we did not have air conditioning.

Neil
So, Radhika is saying that air conditioning is **life-saving**. It literally stops people from dying.

Georgie
Yes, and she makes the point that there are many parts of the world that we would not be able to **inhabit** – that means live in – without this technology.

Neil
OK Georgie. So, it sounds like air conditioning has a lot of good things about it. Is it all positive, though?

Georgie
No. There are some serious downsides. So, one big problem with air conditioning is the amount of energy it uses. Let's hear more from Radhika talking to The Climate Question:

Dr Radhika Khosla
When air conditioning becomes the first, go-to solution for how we deal with the increased, prolonged and extreme heat that we're going to face and are facing, it places stresses across the system that are not able to be met. So, you know, we're going to see **the grid** collapse. We're going to see emissions rise. We're going to

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see all kinds of other impacts that actually are quite detrimental. And we reach a **vicious cycle**, because then you're in a world where it's getting warmer. We're using air conditioning to be able to protect ourselves. That's leading to more emissions and more energy use. That is then making the world warmer. And then we need more air conditioning.

Neil
We heard about **the grid**. **The grid** is the network that distributes electricity across towns, cities and countries. If people are trying to use more electricity than it can cope with, then **the grid** can collapse – you get power cuts, which is when you can't get any electricity.

Georgie
We heard that air conditioning creates emissions, which can lead the world to warm up, which means we then need more air conditioning. This makes the world even warmer and so on. And Radhika calls this a **vicious cycle**. A **vicious cycle**, or a **vicious circle,** is where a solution to a problem actually makes it worse, which means you have to do more and that makes the problem even worse still.

Neil
OK. Well, that sounds like a bit of a problem. What are the solutions?

Georgie
Well, Radhika says that there are some things we should try first before using air conditioning, which will still be important. Here she is again talking to The Climate Question.

Dr Radhika Khosla
So, one of the most important things is to do **passive cooling** first. Now, **passive cooling** is when we take steps to provide thermal comfort that are not energy intensive. Some of the most important ones are first to cut solar gain, which is through things like **shading**.

Neil
Passive cooling is where you cool your house down without using a lot of energy.

Georgie
Yes, heat from the sun can be blocked by **shading**, which could be with trees, curtains or blinds.

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Neil
OK Georgie. So, **passive cooling** and **shading** – that sounds really easy. Is it that simple?

Georgie
No, that's not all we have to do. Radhika also talks about the importance of using sustainable energy to power the air conditioning that we still will need.

Neil
OK Georgie. It's time, I think, for you to give the answer to the question you asked us.

Georgie
Yes, Neil. I asked you what modern air conditioning was used for when it was first invented in 1902.

Neil
And I had a wild guess. I said c) to clean air. But you know what? I'm feeling pretty confident now.

Georgie
Sadly, you are incorrect. The correct answer was b) to dry ink. It was invented by Willis Carrier at a printing company in Brooklyn, New York.

Neil
OK. Let's recap the vocabulary we learned in this programme, starting with **life-saving**, which describes something that stops people from dying.

Georgie
If it's possible to **inhabit** somewhere, that means it's possible to live there.

Neil
The grid is the system or network that distributes electricity across towns, cities, and countries.

Georgie
A **vicious cycle** is where a solution to a problem also makes it worse, meaning the problem just keeps getting even worse as you try to fix it.

Neil
Passive cooling is where you make a building cooler without using a lot of power.

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Georgie
And **shading** is blocking the sun's light and heat.

Neil
Once again, our six minutes are up. Test what you've learned with the worksheet on our website, bbclearningenglish.com.

Georgie
Thank you for joining us. Goodbye.

Neil
Goodbye!

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VOCABULARY

life-saving
used to stop people from dying

inhabit
live in

the grid
the system or network that distributes electricity across different locations

vicious cycle
situation where one problem leads to another problem, which then makes the first problem worse, leading to a chain of events where each cause and effect makes the original problem even worse

passive cooling
making a building cooler without using a lot of power

shading
blocking the sun's light and heat

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